

Word family: **last** / lasts / lasted / lasting / lastly

Base word: last

Third-person singular: lasts

Past tense: lasted

Past participle: lasted

-ing form: lasting

Related forms: lasting, lastly

Useful constructions/extensions: last year, last week, last time, the last person/thing, last place, last chance, last minute, at last, last but not least, last for + time, last until + time, make something last, lasting impression, lasting effect

Part of speech: adjective (形容詞) / determiner (限定詞) / adverb (副詞) / noun (名詞) / verb (動詞)

Your passage contains:

> “One of the most challenging things I have ever done was giving a formal presentation in English at a company event **last year**.”

Here, **last** means:

the previous one immediately before the present year.

Meaning in this passage

In:

> **last year**

last does **not** mean “final forever.”

It means:

the year immediately before the current one.

Meaning: The most recent previous year before now.

繁體中文: 緊接現在之前的上一年; 去年

中文翻譯:

> “One of the most challenging things I have ever done was giving a formal presentation in English at a company event last year.”

「我做過其中一件最具挑戰性的事情，就是**去年**在一個公司活動上用英文作正式簡報。」

So:

****last year = 去年／緊接今年之前的一年****

This is one of the most important everyday meanings of ****last****.

1. ****last + time period (上一個時間段) — 上一個; 剛過去的****

This is the exact sense used in your passage.

****Meaning:**** The most recent previous period before the present one.

Practice 1 — Original

> “I gave a formal presentation at a company event ****last year****.”

「我****去年****在一個公司活動上作了正式簡報。」

Practice 2

> “We met ****last week****.”

「我們****上星期****見過面。」

Practice 3

> “She started her new job ****last month****.”

「她****上個月****開始了新工作。」

****last + time period = 緊接現在之前的那一個時間段****

Common:

* last year = 去年

* last month = 上個月

* last week = 上星期

* last night = 昨晚

* last Monday = 上一個星期一

2. **last time (上一次) — 上一次; 最近一次**

Practice 4

> “The **last time** I gave a presentation, I was extremely nervous.”

「我**上一次**做簡報時非常緊張。」

Practice 5

> “When was the **last time** you spoke in public?”

「你**上一次**公開演講是甚麼時候？」

the last time = 在目前之前最近發生的那一次

This does not necessarily mean:

> the final time ever

It usually means:

> most recent previous occasion.

3. **last = final in a sequence (最後的) — 最後的; 末尾的**

This is a different major meaning.

Meaning: Coming after all others in a sequence, order, list, or period.

Practice 6

> “She was the **last person** to leave the room.”

「她是**最後一個**離開房間的人。」

Practice 7

> “The **last slide** contains the conclusion.”

「**最後一張投影片**是結論。」

****last** = 在一個次序、系列或過程中排在所有其他項目之後的******

4. ****the last + noun** = final remaining one (最後剩下的) — 最後一個／最後剩下的******

Practice 8

> “I used the ****last sheet of paper****.”

「我用了****最後一張紙****。」

Practice 9

> “She took the ****last seat**** in the room.”

「她坐了房間裡****最後一個空位****。」

****the last + noun** = 在其他同類事物已被使用／消失後最後剩下的一個******

This combines “final in sequence” with “remaining.”

5. ****last place** (最後一名) — 最後名次; 包尾******

Common in competitions and rankings.

Practice 10

> “Their team finished in ****last place****.”

「他們的隊伍最後排名****最末／包尾****。」

Practice 11

> “He came ****last**** in the race.”

「他在比賽中****最後一名****。」

****last place / come last** = 在排名或比賽中位於所有參賽者之後******

6. **last = least likely / least suitable person(最不可能的) — 最不可能的; 最不適合的**

A very useful figurative extension.

Practice 12

> “He is the **last person** I would ask for advice.”

「他是我**最不可能去請教意見的人**。」

Practice 13

> “She is the **last person** who would deliberately hurt someone.”

「她是**最不可能故意傷害別人的人**。」

the last person/thing = 在所有可能選擇中最不可能、最不適合或最不希望的那一個

This is not about chronological order.

7. **last chance/opportunity(最後機會) — 最後一次機會**

Practice 14

> “This is your **last chance** to register.”

「這是你**最後一次報名機會**。」

Practice 15

> “The presentation was my **last opportunity** to convince the managers.”

「這次簡報是我說服經理們的**最後一次機會**。」

last chance = 如果這一次錯過, 之後便沒有同樣機會

This is genuinely final, not merely “most recent.”

8. **last minute(最後一刻) — 最後關頭; 臨近截止時**

A very common fixed expression.

Practice 16

> “I made one small change at the **last minute**.”

「我在**最後一刻**作了一個小修改。」

Practice 17

> “Don’t leave your preparation until the **last minute**.”

「不要等到**最後關頭**才準備。」

at the last minute = 在某件事情即將開始、截止或不能再更改之前的最後短時間內

9. **last-minute + noun** (臨時的; 最後一刻的) — 臨時作出的

Practice 18

> “There was a **last-minute change** to the schedule.”

「時間表有一項**最後一刻才作出的臨時改動**。」

Practice 19

> “She received a **last-minute invitation**.”

「她在活動前不久才收到一個**臨時邀請**。」

last-minute = 在事情即將發生前很短時間才決定或安排的

10. **the last + number + time period** (過去最近一段時間) — 過去……; 最近……

Practice 20

> “I have been very busy for the **last three weeks**.”

「我在**過去三星期**一直都很忙。」

Practice 21

> “Sales have increased over the **last five years**.”

「銷售額在**過去五年**有所增加。」

the last + period = 從現在往前計算的一段最近時間

Important contrast:

> **last year** = 去年

but:

> **the last year** = 過去一年／最近十二個月

These are not always the same.

11. **last** = most recent one (最近一次／最新的一個) — 最近的; 上一個

Practice 22

> “I didn’t enjoy his **last film**.”

「我不太喜歡他**最近上一部電影**。」

Practice 23

> “Her **last email** contained the final details.”

「她**最近上一封電郵**包含最後的細節。」

last + item = 在目前之前最近出現、完成或收到的同類項目

Depending on context, this may mean:

* most recent;

* final.

Context decides.

12. **someone's last + work/book/film(最後作品) — 生前／職業生涯最後的**

Here **last** can genuinely mean **final ever**.

Practice 24

> “This was the director's **last film**.”

「這是那位導演的**最後一部電影**。」

Practice 25

> “Her **last public appearance** took place in London.”

「她的**最後一次公開露面**是在倫敦。」

last = 某人之後再沒有同類作品、活動或表現的最終一次

The ambiguity between:

> **most recent**

and:

> **final ever**

is very important.

13. **last = previous office-holder/person(前任／上一位) — 上一任; 之前的**

Practice 26

> “The **last manager** introduced the current policy.”

「**上一任經理**制定了目前的政策。」

Practice 27

> “The **last owner** renovated the building.”

「**上一任業主**翻新了這棟建築。」

last + person in a role = 在現任之前最近擔任該角色的人

Natural Chinese often uses:

* 上一任

* 前任

rather than 「最後的」.

14. **last = continue for a period of time (持續) — 持續; 延續**

Now **last** is a **verb**.

This is a completely different core meaning.

Meaning: To continue existing or happening for a particular length of time.

Practice 28

> “The presentation **lasted** twenty minutes.”

「簡報**持續**了二十分鐘。」

Practice 29

> “The meeting **lasted** much longer than expected.”

「會議**持續**的時間**比預期長得多**。」

last = 某件事情持續存在、發生或進行一段時間

15. **last for + time period (持續多久) — 持續.....時間**

Practice 30

> “The training session will **last for two hours**.”

「培訓課程會**持續兩小時**。」

Practice 31

> “The effects can **last for several days**.”

「這些影響可以**持續幾天**。」

last for + period = 持續指定的一段時間

Note:

> **for** is often optional.

Both are natural:

> “The meeting lasted two hours.”

> “The meeting lasted for two hours.”

16. **last until + time** (持續至.....) — 一直持續到.....

Practice 32

> “The event **lasted until midnight**.”

「活動**一直持續到午夜**。」

Practice 33

> “The offer will **last until Friday**.”

「這項優惠會**持續到星期五**。」

last until + time = 一直維持或進行到某個指定時間點

17. **last through + period/event** (捱過／維持整段時間) — 持續整個.....

Practice 34

> “The battery should **last through the whole presentation**.”

「電池應該足以**撐完整場簡報**。」

Practice 35

> “The food needs to **last through the weekend**.”

「這些食物要**足夠維持整個週末**。」

****last through something = 在整段指定時間／事件內一直維持足夠或可用狀態****

18. ****object/product lasts (耐用) — 維持可用; 耐用****

Practice 36

> “These headphones should **last** for years.”

「這副耳機應該可以**用很多年／很耐用**。」

Practice 37

> “A good suit can **last** a long time.”

「一套好的西裝可以**穿很久／很耐用**。」

****something lasts = 某物在一段長時間內仍保持可用、不損壞或有效****

This is a durability sense derived from continuation.

19. ****supply/resource lasts (夠用) — 足以維持; 夠用一段時間****

Practice 38

> “We have enough water to **last** three days.”

「我們有足夠食水, **可以用三天**。」

Practice 39

> “Will the battery **last** the whole day?”

「電池**夠不夠用一整天**？」

resource lasts = 某項供應、能源或資源足夠支撐到某個時間／完成某段活動

Natural Chinese often uses:

- * 夠用
- * 撐得住
- * 維持到

rather than 「持續」.

20. **person lasts (堅持／撐下去) — 撐得住; 堅持**

This is a common figurative extension.

Practice 40

> “I was exhausted and didn’t think I could **last** another hour.”

「我已經筋疲力盡, 覺得自己**再也撐不了一個小時**。」

Practice 41

> “She only **lasted** six months in the demanding job.”

「她在那份要求很高的工作中只**撐了六個月**。」

a person lasts = 在困難、疲累或高壓環境下仍能繼續承受／堅持

21. **relationship/arrangement lasts (維持) — 維持; 延續**

Practice 42

> “Their friendship has **lasted** for decades.”

「他們的友誼已經**維持了幾十年**。」

Practice 43

> “The agreement did not **last** long.”

「這項協議沒有**維持很久**。」

relationship/arrangement lasts = 某種關係、協議或狀態持續存在

22. **effect/impression/memory lasts** (效果／印象持續) — 持續存在；久久不散

Practice 44

> “The experience **lasted** in my memory for years.”

「這次經歷多年來一直**留在我的記憶中**。」

Practice 45

> “The feeling of confidence **lasted** long after the presentation.”

「簡報結束後，那種自信的感覺仍然**持續了很久**。」

last = 某種效果、感受或印象在事情結束後仍然存在

23. **make something last** (使某物用得更久) — 延長使用時間；節省使用

Practice 46

> “We need to **make the food last** until Friday.”

「我們要令這些食物**夠吃到星期五**。」

Practice 47

> “Lowering the screen brightness can **make the battery last longer**.”

「降低螢幕亮度可以令電池**用得更久**。」

make something last = 採取方法令某種資源、產品或效果維持更長時間

24. **lasting = continuing for a long time (持久的) — 持久的; 長期的**

A very useful derivative.

Practice 48

> “The experience had a **lasting effect** on my confidence.”

「這次經歷對我的自信產生了**持久的影響**。」

Practice 49

> “They built a **lasting friendship**.”

「他們建立了一段**長久的友誼**。」

lasting = 能夠長時間維持、不容易消失或結束的

Common:

- * lasting effect
- * lasting impact
- * lasting impression
- * lasting relationship
- * lasting peace

25. **lasting impression (持久印象) — 深刻而長久的印象**

Practice 50

> “Her presentation made a **lasting impression** on the audience.”

「她的簡報給觀眾留下了**深刻而持久的印象**。」

Practice 51

> “His kindness left a **lasting impression** on me.”

「他的善意給我留下了**長久而深刻的印象**。」

lasting impression = 某人／某事造成的印象在很長時間後仍然存在

26. **lasting effect/impact**(持久影響) — 長期影響

Practice 52

> “The experience had a **lasting impact** on her career.”

「這次經歷對她的事業產生了**長期影響**。」

Practice 53

> “Good training can have a **lasting effect** on performance.”

「良好的培訓可以對表現產生**持久影響**。」

lasting effect/impact = 在原來事件結束後仍然持續存在的長期影響

27. **at last**(終於) — 終於;最終

A very common fixed expression.

Practice 54

> “At **last**, it was my turn to speak.”

「**終於**輪到我發言了。」

Practice 55

> “After months of preparation, the day arrived **at last**.”

「經過幾個月準備, 那一天**終於**到了。」

at last = 經過長時間等待、困難或延誤後, 某件期待中的事情終於發生

It often carries a feeling of:

* relief;

* impatience ending;

* long-awaited completion.

28. **last but not least(最後但同樣重要) — 最後但同樣重要的是**

A very common presentation expression.

Practice 56

> “And **last but not least**, I’d like to thank my team.”

「**最後但同樣重要的是**，我想感謝我的團隊。」

Practice 57

> “**Last but not least**, preparation helped me stay calm.”

「**最後但同樣重要的是**，充分準備令我保持冷靜。」

last but not least = 雖然最後提到，但重要性並不比前面的項目低

This is especially useful in speeches and presentations.

29. **last thing(最不想／最後才會做的事) — 最不想做的事情**

A common figurative pattern.

Practice 58

> “The **last thing** I wanted was to forget my script.”

「我**最不希望發生的事**就是忘記講稿。」

Practice 59

> “The **last thing** we need is another delay.”

「我們**最不需要的東西**就是再一次延誤。」

the last thing someone wants/needs = 在所有可能情況中最不希望／最不需要發生的事情

This relates to the “least desirable/likely” sense rather than literal final order.

30. **one last + noun (再最後一次) — 最後再.....一次／一個**

Practice 60

> “I checked my slides **one last time** before going on stage.”

「上台前我**最後再檢查了一次**投影片。」

Practice 61

> “Let me ask **one last question**.”

「讓我**最後再問一個問題**。」

one last + noun = 在結束之前再進行最後一次同類行動／事情

Very common in speech.

31. **last resort (最後手段) — 萬不得已的最後辦法**

A common fixed expression.

Practice 62

> “Cancelling the event should be a **last resort**.”

「取消活動只應該是**萬不得已時採取的最後辦法**。」

Practice 63

> “We would use legal action only as a **last resort**.”

「我們只會把法律行動作為**最後手段**。」

last resort = 其他合理方法都無效／不可行後才採用的最後辦法

32. **last word (最後決定權／最後發言) — 最後決定權; 最後一句話**

This expression has more than one use.

A. Final statement

> “He had the **last word** in the argument.”

「那場爭論中最後是他**說了最後一句**。」

B. Final authority

> “The director has the **last word** on hiring decisions.”

「招聘決定由董事擁有**最終決定權**。」

have the last word = 作最後發言, 或擁有事情的最終決定權

Context decides.

33. **last word in** + technology/style (最新／最先進事物) — 最先進的; 最新成果

A separate established expression.

Practice 64

> “The system is the **last word in** security technology.”

「這個系統代表保安科技的**最新／最先進水平**。」

Practice 65

> “At the time, the hotel was the **last word in** luxury.”

「當時那家酒店代表了奢華設計的**最高最新水平**。」

the last word in something = 某個領域最新、最先進或極具代表性的事物

Somewhat idiomatic and often stylistically emphatic.

34. **lastly** = finally in a list/discussion (最後) — 最後; 最後一點

A related adverb.

Practice 66

> “**Lastly**, remember to speak slowly and clearly.”

「**最後**，記得慢慢而清楚地說話。」

Practice 67

> “**Lastly**, I want to thank everyone who helped.”

「**最後**，我想感謝所有幫助過我的人。」

lastly = 用來引出一系列觀點、步驟或項目中的最後一項

It is especially useful in structured writing and speech.

Important distinction: **last** = previous vs **last** = final

This is the most important ambiguity.

Previous / most recent:

> “I saw her **last week**.”

= 我**上星期**見過她。

> “His **last email** was very short.”

= 他**上一封／最近一封**電郵很短。

Final:

> “This is the **last chapter** of the book.”

= 這是書的**最後一章**。

> “This was his **last performance**.”

= 這是他的**最後一次演出**。

So **last** can mean:

most recent before now

or:

final with nothing after it

Context determines which.

Important distinction: last year vs the last year

This is crucial.

last year

= the calendar year immediately before this year

「去年」

> “I changed jobs last year.”

the last year

often means:

= the most recent twelve-month period / a particular final year

「過去一年／最後一年」

> “I have learned a lot in the last year.”

「我在過去一年學了很多東西。」

The article changes the time reference.

Important distinction: last week vs the last week

last week

= 上星期

the last week

can mean:

1. the final week of a period;
2. the most recent seven-day period, depending on context.

> “The last week of the course was very busy.”

= 課程的**最後一星期**非常忙。

So learners should not automatically translate both as 「上星期」.

Important distinction: **last vs latest**

These are commonly confused.

last

can mean:

- * previous;
- * final.

> “my last job”

could mean:

- * my previous job;
- * my final job before retirement, depending on context.

latest

means:

> most recent/newest

> “the latest version”

= **最新版本**

> “the latest news”

= **最新消息**

So:

latest = 最新的

while:

last = 上一個／最後的

depending on context.

Important distinction: **last vs previous**

previous

clearly means:

> before the current one

> “my previous manager”

= 我的上一任經理

last

can mean the same:

> “my last manager”

but can sometimes be ambiguous with “final.”

For precise formal writing, **previous** may remove ambiguity.

Important distinction: **last vs final**

final

strongly means:

> at the end; no more after it

last

can mean:

* final;

* previous/most recent.

Compare:

> “his **final** presentation”

strongly suggests he would not give another one.

> “his **last** presentation”

could mean:

* his most recent presentation;

* his final presentation.

Context matters.

Important distinction: **last vs lately**

These are unrelated in modern meaning despite similar appearance.

last

> final / previous / continue

lately

> recently

> “I’ve been busy **lately**.”

= 我**最近**很忙。

Do not interpret:

> **lately**

as simply an adverb form of **last** meaning “finally.”

Important distinction: **last vs lasting**

last — verb

> “The meeting **lasted** two hours.”

= 會議**持續了兩小時**。

lasting — adjective

> “The meeting had a **lasting impact**.”

= 會議產生了**持久影響**。

So:

last = 持續

lasting = 能持續很久的／持久的

Important distinction: **last vs remain**

These can overlap.

last

focuses strongly on duration:

> “The battery lasted ten hours.”

= 電池維持了十小時。

remain

focuses on continuing to be in a state/place:

> “The door remained open.”

= 門一直保持開著。

You would not normally say:

> “The door lasted open.”

So:

last = 時間上持續多久

remain = 保持某種狀態／仍然存在

Important distinction: **last vs survive**

last

can describe continued existence or usefulness:

> “The shoes lasted five years.”

survive

emphasizes not dying, being destroyed, or disappearing despite danger/difficulty:

> “The company survived the crisis.”

So:

last = 維持／耐用多久

survive = 經歷危險或困難後仍然存在／存活

Important distinction: **at last vs finally**

They often overlap.

at last

usually carries stronger emotional emphasis after waiting/difficulty:

> “At last, the presentation was over!”

= 簡報**終於**結束了！

finally

can also mean “eventually,” but can additionally introduce the final point in a list:

> “Finally, I thanked the audience.”

= **最後**，我感謝觀眾。

You normally would not use **at last** merely to introduce the final bullet point.

Important distinction: **lastly vs finally**

Both can introduce the final item.

lastly

specifically signals:

> this is the last item in my list

finally

can signal:

* final item;

* eventual outcome after time/difficulty.

Compare:

> “Lastly, check your timing.”

= 最後一點：檢查時間。

> “I finally felt calm.”

= 我**終於**平靜下來。

Lastly cannot replace **finally** in the second sentence.

Family-extension sweep

The practical **last** family is rich mainly because of its different grammatical functions and fixed constructions:

- * **last year/week/month** = 上一個時間段
- * **last time** = 上一次
- * **last — final** = 最後的
- * **the last remaining one** = 最後剩下的一個
- * **last place / come last** = 最後一名
- * **the last person I would... ** = 最不可能／最不适合的人
- * **last chance** = 最後機會
- * **last minute** = 最後一刻
- * **last-minute** = 最後關頭才作出的
- * **the last three years** = 過去三年
- * **last — most recent** = 最近上一個
- * **last — final ever** = 最終的／最後一次
- * **last manager/owner** = 上一任
- * **last — verb** = 持續
- * **last for + period** = 持續一段時間
- * **last until + time** = 持續到某時間
- * **last through + period** = 撐過整段時間
- * **product lasts** = 耐用
- * **resource lasts** = 夠用
- * **person lasts** = 撐下去
- * **relationship lasts** = 維持
- * **make something last** = 使某物維持更久
- * **lasting** = 持久的
- * **lasting impression** = 持久印象
- * **lasting effect/impact** = 長期影響
- * **at last** = 終於
- * **last but not least** = 最後但同樣重要的是
- * **the last thing I want/need** = 最不希望／最不需要的事情
- * **one last time/question** = 最後再一次／一個
- * **last resort** = 最後手段
- * **have the last word** = 最終發言／決定權

* **the last word in something** = 某領域最新／最先進水平

* **lastly** = 最後一點

The main semantic branches are:

> **previous / most recent**

> **final in order**

> **least likely/desirable**

> **continue/endure**

with several common fixed expressions extending from those ideas.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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last + time period	緊接現在之前的上一個時間段; 上個／去年等
the last time	在目前之前最近發生的那一次; 上一次
last — final in sequence	在次序、系列或過程中排在所有其他項目之後的; 最後的
the last remaining one	其他同類項目已用完／離開後最後剩下的一個
last place / come last	在排名或比賽中位於所有其他參與者之後; 最後一名
the last person/thing I would...	在所有選擇中最不可能、最不適合或最不希望的那一個
last chance	如果這次錯過, 之後便不再有同樣機會
last minute	某事即將開始、截止或不能再更改之前的最後短時間
last-minute	在事情即將發生前很短時間才決定或安排的
the last + time period	從現在往前計算的一段最近時間; 過去.....
last — most recent item	在目前之前最近出現、完成、收到或發生的同類項目
last — final ever	某人／某事之後再沒有同類活動、作品或階段的最終一次
last manager/owner/etc.	在現任之前最近擔任同一角色的人; 上一任／前任
last — continue	某件事情、狀態或活動持續存在／進行一段時間
last for + period	持續指定長度的一段時間
last until + time	一直維持或進行到某個指定時間點
last through + period	在整段指定時間／活動內一直維持足夠或可用狀態
product lasts	某物長時間保持可用、不損壞或有效; 耐用
resource lasts	某項資源／能源足夠維持到指定時間; 夠用
person lasts	在困難、疲勞或高壓情況下仍能繼續承受／堅持
relationship/arrangement lasts	某種關係、協議或狀態繼續存在
make something last	採取方法令某物、資源或效果維持更長時間
lasting	能長時間維持、不容易消失或結束的; 持久的

lasting impression	在很長時間後仍然存在的深刻印象	
lasting effect/impact	原來事件結束後仍持續存在的長期影響	
at last	經過等待、延誤或困難後某件事終於發生	
last but not least	雖然最後提到, 但重要性不比之前項目低	
the last thing someone wants/needs	在所有可能情況中最不希望／最不需要出現的事情	
one last + noun	在結束前再進行最後一次同類行動／事情	
last resort	其他合理方法都失敗或不可行後才使用的最後辦法	
have the last word	作最後發言, 或對某件事情擁有最終決定權	
the last word in something	某個領域最新、最先進或極具代表性的事物	
lastly	用來引出一系列觀點、步驟或項目中的最後一項	

For your original passage

> “One of the most challenging things I have ever done was giving a formal presentation in English at a company event ****last year****.”

The exact meaning is:

****last = 緊接目前年份之前的上一個****

Therefore:

> ****last year****

= ****「去年／緊接今年之前的一年」****

Here ****last**** does ****not**** mean:

> ****最後一年****

and it does not imply that the year was somehow the final year of a longer sequence.

It is the everyday ****previous-time**** meaning.

So the key mapping in your passage is:

****last year = 去年****

The most important learner contrasts are:

> ****last year****

> = 去年

> ****the last year****

> = 過去一年／最後一年，視語境而定

> ****the last slide****

> = 最後一張投影片

> ****my last presentation****

> = 我最近一次簡報／我的最後一次簡報，語境決定

> ****the meeting lasted an hour****

> = 會議持續了一小時

> ****the battery should last all day****

> = 電池應該夠用一整天

> ****a lasting impression****

> = 持久而深刻的印象

> ****at last****

> = 終於

That is why ****last**** is especially valuable polysemy material: a learner who knows only 「最後的」 could easily misunderstand your original phrase ****last year****, which means simply ****「去年」****, not ****「最後一年」****.